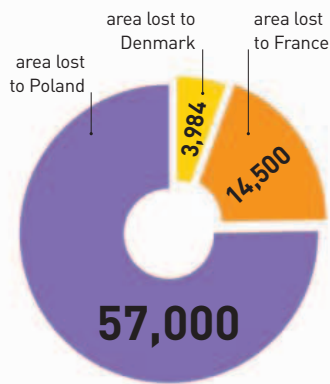




The "Big Four"—David Lloyd George, Vittorio Orlando, Georges Clemenceau, and Woodrow Wilson—meet amiably at the Paris Peace Conference.

IN JANUARY 1919, LEADERS OF THE VICTOR COUNTRIES FROM WORLD WAR I met for a peace conference in Paris. US President Woodrow Wilson's liberal idealism was the focus for popular hopes that a new and better world would be built on the ruins of the old. Wilson was one of the "**Big Four**" who dominated the proceedings in Paris, the others being French prime minister Georges Clemenceau (1841–1929), British prime minister David Lloyd George (1863–1945), and Italian prime minister Vittorio Orlando (1860–1952). Each European leader had his own agenda, inevitably dominated by issues of national self-interest. Wilson's idealism expressed itself in an agreement to create a **League of Nations**, which was to provide "collective security" against



German loss of territory
After World War I, Germany lost 13 percent of its territory. Most went to the new state of Poland, while France regained Alsace-Lorraine.

aggression and replace war with negotiated settlement of disputes, but Clemenceau believed the best guarantee for the future peace of France was in a permanent weakening of Germany.

Defeat in war had reduced Germany to a state of economic and social collapse. In January, communist revolutionaries, known as the **Spartacists**, tried to imitate the success of the Bolsheviks in Russia (see 1917) by staging an uprising in Berlin. The **attempted revolution** was crushed by the army and right-wing paramilitary Freikorps; the two most prominent Spartacist leaders, Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg, were captured and killed. In February, an elected assembly, sitting in the city of Weimar, set about drawing up a constitution for an impeccably

democratic republic, but on the streets of Germany **extremism of right and left continued to flourish**. In the southern German state of Bavaria, communists proclaimed a Soviet regime in April, only to be crushed by the army and Freikorps in May.

With Germany in no position to resume hostilities, the victorious Allies were able to impose peace terms in the **Versailles Treaty** without negotiation. Germany lost all its colonies and substantial territory in Europe. The European territorial loss consisted largely of areas needed to form the **new state of Poland**, and Alsace-Lorraine, which Germany had taken from France during the Franco-Prussian War (see 1870). Tight restrictions were placed on German armed forces and the Rhineland was demilitarized.

The Germans were also required to make reparations payments, which were justified by the assertion that Germany had been guilty of starting the war. The "**war guilt**" clause

Revolutionary leader
Trotsky's organizational and leadership skills were essential to Bolshevik success in Russia. He is seen here addressing troops of the Red Army.

outraged Germans more than any other part of the treaty. The crew of the German High Seas Fleet—interned since the armistice at **Scapa Flow** in the Orkney Islands north of Scotland—scuttled their vessels as an act of defiance. But left with no choice, German delegates signed the treaty in the Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles on June 28.

While peace was being formalized in Western Europe, **civil war raged in Russia**, as Lenin's Bolshevik government fought for survival against various "White"

counter-revolutionary armies. The Whites had the backing of foreign powers, who landed intervention forces at ports around Russia—US and Japanese at Vladivostok, French at Odessa, and British at Murmansk and Arkhangelsk—but these foreign interventions were half-hearted and mostly short-lived. The Bolshevik People's Commissar for War, **Leon Trotsky** (1879–1940), created a mass Red Army by conscripting peasants at gunpoint and subjecting them to harsh discipline. Fighting between the



Russian Red Army cap badge
The hammer-and-plow insignia from the Civil War period symbolizes the union of industrial workers and peasants in the revolutionary cause.

